

Revenue Service (IRS) also provides incentives and perks for positive money behaviors like saving for retirement.

Accountant Dan loads me with information come tax time, and though he talks slowly like a very patient teacher, I still like to record our meetings so I can listen back later. Recording meetings is a good trick if the other party is comfortable with it. I was embarrassed to ask at first, but it's even more embarrassing to nod, pretending you comprehend what you need to do, and then totally flake on following up. At one of our first in-person meetings at his office in Westwood, I asked him how many people my age are actually sitting down to do all of this versus ignoring it completely. He said that in his experience as a financial advisor, it's a mix of both.

The IRS must know no one is keeping track of their shit. (Am I asking to be audited? I'm kidding, IRS! I keep track of everything! We all do!) Before 2016, I'd just take a bunch of tax-related papers to H&R Block. (You can also use online tax services like TurboTax, but those always intimidated me.) I had no idea what deductions I was writing off, what deductions I *could* write off, what the accountant at H&R Block was doing to calculate said write-offs, and what papers I even needed to be turning in. It was all a mess.

Here's what I found out about that paperwork:

WHAT IS A W-2?

A W-2 is a form you receive from your employer and fill out as a full-time employee to indicate how much in taxes will be withheld from your paycheck. Depending on the numbers you put in, you can either get your full salary and pay a lump sum in taxes, or you can have wages withheld, and when tax time comes, you might get back a refund. You get a refund if the government decides it took too much out of your check weekly. That lump sum is a weird financial apology.

Which is better? It depends on your income and lifestyle. When I was getting regular paychecks in NYC, I would usually get my wages taken out for taxes upfront and receive a lower salary every week. Then I'd be pleasantly surprised at the end of the year by my refund. But because I'm an irresponsible person, I